

Chapter 88-1

Liang Shi spent the entire afternoon at Liang Xinzhou's home.

Because Yu Wan knew a lot—she practically reconstructed the entire incident.

Yu Wan's family had previously had a long-term partnership with Qida Company, so they knew Qi Xiangui, and naturally also knew Yang Jiani.

In Yu Wan's impression, Yang Jiani was a complete idealist. Yu Wan was still young when she met her, and at that time, Yu Wan affectionately called her "Auntie." Back then, the Yang family was still a wealthy household in Haizhou City. But circumstances changed overnight—the Yang family went bankrupt and was liquidated, and Yang Jiani married Qi Xiangui in that critical moment.

Yang Jiani was a pampered young lady from a wealthy family, raised with money. Marrying down to Qi Xiangui, she was naturally still coddled and indulged.

The original Qida didn't have its current scale. It was Yang Jiani who, relying on her family's former connections, single-handedly elevated Qida to its current position.

But after obtaining Yang Jiani's connections and resources, Qi Xiangui always felt inferior. Especially since Yang Jiani had been spoiled growing up and had quite a temper.

When they first got married, Yang Jiani often lost her temper at Qi Xiangui. Later, when Qi Xiangui's business improved, he would go out socializing and drinking with hostesses¹. The old dance halls were a mixed bag of people, and many transactions were conducted openly. Qi Xiangui frequently visited such places. When Yang Jiani found out, she made a scene and demanded a divorce.

As a result, Qi Xiangui beat her—and broke one of her ribs.

Once domestic violence begins, it can never be stopped.

Yang Jiani had originally wanted a divorce, but then discovered she was pregnant. Alone in this world with no one to turn to, the child in her belly was her only blood relative.

So she endured for the sake of the child.

Everything that followed was like the fate of all domestic violence victims in this world.

Yang Jiani endured for the child's sake, but Qi Xiangui only escalated his abuse.

When Yang Jiani was seven months pregnant, he nearly beat her into a miscarriage.

The child was saved only because Yang Jiani lay in bed completely immobile, receiving IV fluids for an entire month. During that time, Yu Wan had accompanied her mother to visit Yang Jiani as she lay in bed.

Yu Wan was very young at the time. When she saw Yang Jiani, she would comfort her not to be sad.

In her memory, Yang Jiani would gently stroke her face and say, "In the future, Auntie will have a cute little child just like you. Auntie won't be sad."

When leaving the hospital, Yu Wan would ask her mother, "Why doesn't Auntie Yang get a divorce? Uncle Qi isn't good to her."

"Because Auntie Yang has nowhere to go now," Yu Wan's mother replied.

Once you enter a wealthy family, you're in as deep as the sea².

In these wealthy families, everyone has their own troubles to bear, and no one can pull anyone else out of the abyss.

Yu Wan's mother had taught Yu Wan this truth from an early age.

Yu Wan's family later gradually grew distant from the Qi family, and she rarely saw Yang Jiani anymore.

It was only when Qi Jiao was in her third year of middle school³ that Yu Wan learned of the news that Qi Jiao had attempted suicide by jumping off a building. She was shocked when she got home, but her mother said she had been rescued.

That spring was particularly long. Snow was still falling in April, covering the branches that had already sprouted new buds. Qi Jiao stood on the rooftop of the school building and, with almost no hesitation, jumped.

But the rescue team arrived in time. She landed on thick cushioning mats and only injured her leg.

Yu Wan had even visited her once. By then, Yu Wan was already in university.

When Yang Jiani entered the hospital room, Qi Jiao would shrink back in fear.

After that came an early summer when the branches were growing wildly. Yu Wan saw her mother sitting dazedly on the sofa, holding a photo of Qi Jiao.

When Yu Wan asked what had happened, she learned that Yang Jiani had accidentally pushed Qi Jiao down the stairs. She had hit her head—and died from the impact.

Yu Wan's mother and Qiu Zimin had been going to see Yang Jiani at that time and witnessed the scene with their own eyes.

...

It was a sad and heavy matter to speak of.

If Liang Shi hadn't brought it up today, Yu Wan would have buried this matter in her heart for the rest of her life.

Yu Wan wasn't very clear about what happened afterward. She only knew that Yang Jiani had somehow found someone who looked almost exactly like Qi Jiao, who became the new Qi Jiao.

Apart from them, no one knew the real Qi Jiao was already dead.

After hearing all this, Liang Xinzhou's brows were deeply furrowed. He asked coldly, "Yang Jiani has a tendency for domestic violence?"

Yu Wan and Liang Shi both nodded in unison. "Yes."

Then Liang Xinzhou looked at Liang Shi. "In your memory..."

He suddenly stopped mid-question, not knowing how to ask.

But Liang Shi smiled and said, "I remember Qi Jiao. We were locked in the basement together. Yang Jiani..."

When mentioning this name, Liang Shi didn't describe her specific actions. She just smiled bitterly. "She's a madwoman."

"Why did she send you there?" Liang Xinzhou's voice was so cold it was nearly freezing. "When did this happen?"

"I can't remember clearly," Liang Shi said. "But there was definitely such a period. As for why, you'd have to ask the person involved."

Liang Shi was smiling, but it was a very distant smile. "Big Brother, I don't really want to make things difficult for you. So you can pretend you don't know about any of this, and you don't have to confront her on my behalf. But if you want me to pretend nothing happened, I can't do that."

The subtext was—you don't have to help me, but you can't stop me.

After a long while, Liang Xinzhou let out a deep breath. "Keep what I've given you. Do whatever you want to do. I won't stop you."

Liang Shi smiled lightly. "Then thank you, Big Brother. If you ever want it back someday, I'll return it to you."

"Have you thought about how you're going to do it?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Shi lowered her eyes and shook her head. "Not yet. There's still too little that I can remember."

Liang Shi didn't ask Yu Wan why she hadn't called the police back then.

A mother accidentally pushing her daughter down the stairs, causing accidental death... it was hard to say.

That Yang Jiani could be deranged enough to quickly find a replacement was beyond everyone's expectations.

Yu Wan said she had seen Yang Jiani at the Liang residence a few times afterward, but she never greeted her. She didn't even dare to look directly at that girl, for fear of having nightmares.

Liang Shi was quite surprised that Yu Wan could be so frank with her.

Before leaving, Yu Wan also advised her not to provoke Yang Jiani, because that woman was a lunatic.

No one knew what a lunatic might do.

Liang Shi agreed.

After returning home that evening and telling Xu Qingzhu about this matter, the two fell into a long silence.

Xu Qingzhu was probably thinking of Su Yao. That night, she video-called Su Yao for over half an hour.

After learning the truth, Liang Shi wanted to contact Gu Xingyue several times but kept putting down her phone.

Gu Xingyue must be in a difficult position right now. She didn't want to pressure her anymore.

Footnotes:

¹ **Drinking with hostesses (喝花酒, hē huā jiǔ):** A phrase referring to the practice of men visiting entertainment establishments where hostesses pour drinks and provide companionship. In the context of business culture, this was often associated with shady dealings, corruption, and infidelity.

² **Once you enter a wealthy family, you're in as deep as the sea (豪門一入深似海):** A famous Chinese saying derived from a Tang Dynasty poem. It means that once you marry into a wealthy and powerful family, you become trapped in its complex web of relationships, obligations, and secrets, making it extremely difficult to leave or maintain your independence.

³ **Third year of middle school (初三):** In the Chinese education system, this refers to the final year of junior high school, typically when students are around 14-15 years old.